Charles Lyell only studied the fossils and spoke of the great antiquity of Creation; Darwin accepted it and accounted on its basis for the differentiation of animal species by theory of Natural Selection. This was in direct conflict with the story of creation given in *The Book of Genesis*.

A storm rose and shook Christianity by roots. The Victorian intellectuals and writers, poets and novelists could not ignore the scientific basis of the theory of evolution propounded by Darwin. Faith was tinged with doubt; an attitudinal change had occurred, best expressed by Tennyson –

> There remains more faith in honest doubt
> Believe me than in half the creeds.

In view of such a spiritual crisis it would not be easy to sum up the Victorian age in a neat phrase. It was an age of prosperity, but also an age of gloomy forebodings; it was an age of imperial expansion, but also an age of colonial uprisings; above all, it was an age of peace, but there was an undercurrent of 'sick hurry and divided aims.'

16.3 TENNYSON: LIFE AND WORKS

Alfred Tennyson was born in August 1809 in Lincolnshire where his father was a rector. It is said that the rectory had an enchanting landscape that moulded the aesthetic taste of Tennyson. Not only did he take in the beautiful topography of his birth place, he tried to compose lines that could match the sights and the sounds that he experienced as a child and as a young man.

Tennyson's father had an academic bent of mind. He made the young boy learn Latin and Greek classics seriously. So when Tennyson came to Cambridge University in 1828 he had sufficient intellectual training to cope with the studies and other challenges of the legendary educational institution.

In Cambridge Tennyson became intimate with Arthur Hallam, the son of the eminent historian. Later on Mr. Hallam was engaged to Tennyson's sister; he died, however, in Vienna on a trip with his father. Tennyson had already written poems that won distinction. But the death of Arthur Hallam shattered him. For some time he was dumb with grief and melancholy. Yet in this period he found poetic composition as a means of psychic relief. He composed short lyrics as his moods dictated him. This continued for a couple of years and the result was *In Memoriam*, a great elegiac poem. The poem is supposed to reflect not only the intense personal sorrow of the poet, but also to represent the chief conflict of the Victorian age – the conflict between science and religion.

The fact that Tennyson could transcend his personal losses and think in a systematic way about the larger concerns and issues of his age is of singular importance. It gives Tennyson's poetry a lasting appeal.

The classical training that his father imparted to him remained a principal stimulus to Tennyson's poetic life. He is one poet who chose a number of medieval and Greek legends as subjects for his works. But in all his works he tried to interpret the life of his times. In other words, the sense of historical continuity gives his perception of modern issues a sharper edge. His poetry makes the readers feel that there exists a sure fusion between the past and the present.

In 1850 Tennyson succeeded as the Poet Laureate and continued to publish poems some of which have political themes. Extensive travels in England and Europe – Holland, Belgium and Switzerland and – further sharpened his vision. He was able to think in a practical manner since he had first-hand experience of social, political and economic changes.

After a fulfilled life of a prolific poet he died in 1892 at the age of 83.

Major Works
Poems, Chiefly Lyrical 1830
The Lady of Shallott and other poems 1832
The Princess 1847
In Memoriam 1847
Maud and other Poems 1855
Enoch Arden 1864
Locksley Hall Sixty Years After 1886
The Idylls of the King 1888

16.4 THE SPLENDOUR FALLS

The two lyrics prescribed for you are extracts from *The Princess*, a poem that Tennyson wrote in his mature years when British political and social issues began to interest him seriously. It is said that *The Princess* covers a number of prominent issues related to women their status, their field of action, their educational and political rights, legal rights of marriage and property. The protagonist of the poem is Ida, a princess who holds extreme feminist views. She has raised an academy for training of women.

Tennyson's characterization of Ida gives a clue to his attitude towards women. Ida is independent minded but in her zeal she has developed attitudes and a temper that make her unfit for reforms that she wishes to carry.

These two lyrics occur at dramatic moments in the narrative and were added by Tennyson in a subsequent edition. Actually, these two lyrics are supreme achievements of Tennyson and can be enjoyed independently.

The first lyric *The Splendour Falls* is a song that occurs after the narrator and others have had a magnificent view of the palace that the princess has shown them. The narrator is simply charmed by this view.

The second lyric is sung by a maid who is specifically ordered to entertain by the princess.

> Then she, 'Let someone sing to us: lighter more
> The minutes fledged with music': and a maid
> of those beside her, smote her harp, and sang

But the aftermath is quite ironic. In a fit of vanity the princess dismisses the tranquillizing effect of song:

She ended with such passion that the tear / she sang of, shook and fell, an erring pearl / lost in her bosom: but with some disdain / Answered the princess, 'If indeed there haunt / About the moulder's lodges of the past so sweet a voice and vague, fatal to men / well needs it we should cram our ears with wool.